



Fig. 11: Whilst checking the e-mail using MS Outlook checking the option ensures that a copy of the e-mail lies in the e-mail server as well

including actual name

(iii) E-mail that warns that an account of yours will be shut down unless you reconfirm your billing information immediately

(iv) An e-mail threatening legal action

(v) E-mail which comes from an account similar but different from the one the company usually uses

(vi) An e-mail that claims 'security compromises' or 'security threats' and requires immediate action

If you suspect that an e-mail is a phishing attempt, the best defence is to never open the e-mail in the first place. But assuming that the e-mail has been already opened, do not reply or click on the link in the e-mail. Verify the message, manually type in the URL of the company into your browser instead of clicking on the embedded link.

4. Sending personal and financial information via e-mail. One should avoid writing to a bank via e-mail with personal and financial information and consider any online store suspicious that requests to send private information via e-mail. The rule of avoiding financial information in e-mails to online businesses also holds true for personal e-mails. If, for example, credit card information has to be shared with your family member, it is far more secure to do so over the phone than via an e-mail.

5. Unsubscribing to newsletters

ters never subscribed to. A common technique used by spammers is to send out thousands of fake newsletters from organisations with an 'unsubscribe' link on the bottom of the newsletter. E-mail users who then enter their e-mail into the supposed 'unsubscribe' list are then sent loads of spam. So if you do not specifically remember subscribing to the newsletter, you are better off just blacklisting the e-mail address, rather than following the link and possibly picking up a Trojan horse or unknowingly signing for yet more spam.

Avoiding malware

1. Trusting your friend's e-mail. Most Internet users are very careful when it comes to e-mails from senders they do not recognise. But when a friend sends an e-mail, all caution goes out of the window as they just assume it is safe because they know that the sender would not intend to hurt them. The truth is, an e-mail from a friend's ID is just as likely to contain a virus or malware as a stranger's.

The reason is that most malware is circulated by people who have no idea they are sending it, because hackers are using their computer as a zombie. It is important to maintain and keep updated e-mail scanning and anti-virus software, and to use it to scan all incoming e-mails.

2. Deleting spam instead of blacklisting it. An e-mail blacklist is a user-created list of e-mail accounts that are labelled as spammers. When an e-mail sender is blacklisted, e-mail client stops trusting these e-mails from this particular sender and starts assuming that they are spam. Unfortunately, most Internet users are often timid to use the blacklist feature on their e-mail client, and instead just delete spam e-mails. Whilst not every piece of spam is from repeat senders, a surprising amount of it is. So by

training to hit the blacklist/spam button instead of the delete button when confronted with spam, one can, in the course of a few months, drastically limit the amount of spam that reaches Inbox.

3. Disabling the e-mail spam filter.

Most e-mail users typically do not start out with a lot of spam in their e-mail account and thus do not value the help that an e-mail spam filter can provide at the beginning of their e-mail usage. Because no spam filter is perfect, initially the hassle of having to look through one's spam box for wrongly blocked e-mails leads many new e-mail users to instead just disable their e-mail spam filter altogether. However, as an e-mail account gets older, it tends to pick up more spam, and without the spam filter, an e-mail account can quickly become unwieldy.

So instead of disabling the filter early on, Internet users should take the time to whitelist e-mails from friends that get caught up in the spam filter. Then, when the levels of spam start to pick up, the e-mail account will remain useful and fewer and fewer friends will get caught up in the filter.

4. Failing to scan all e-mail attachments. Ninety per cent of viruses that infect a computer reach it through an e-mail attachment. Yet, despite this ratio, many people do not scan all incoming e-mail attachments. May be it is our experience with snail mail, but often when we see an e-mail with an attachment from someone we know, we just assume that the mail and its attachment are safe. Of course that assumption is wrong, as most e-mail viruses are sent by zombies that have infected a computer and caused it to send out viruses without the owner even knowing.

What makes this oversight even more scandalous is the fact that a number of free e-mail clients provide a built-in e-mail attachment scanner. For example, if we use Gmail or Yahoo! for our e-mails, every e-mail and attachment sent or received is automatically